

ALEXANDER THE GREAT



IN LESS THAN FOUR YEARS, a brilliant young general created the largest empire the world had ever seen. The empire was the creation of Alexander the Great of Macedon, a gifted leader who inspired tremendous loyalty from his troops. It stretched from Greece in the west to India in the east. Alexander's sudden death at the age of 33 led to the empire's collapse, but it lived on in a series of towns that spread Greek culture eastwards. These cities, all called Alexandria after their founder, opened up a trade between Asia and Europe that survived for centuries.



Early life

Alexander was born in 356 BC, the son of King Philip II of Macedon (r. 359–336 BC). As a young man he went on military campaigns with his father. Alexander won fame for taming a wild black horse called Bucephalus, which stayed with him throughout his whole life.



Aristotle

Alexander was taught by the Athenian philosopher Aristotle (384–322 BC). Aristotle's interests ranged from politics and morality to biology and literature. He shared his enthusiasm for new ideas with his young pupil.



Terracotta figure of the Greek love goddess, Aphrodite

Greece

The heartland of Alexander's empire was his home state of Macedon, northern Greece. Before Alexander became king, Greece was divided into rival city states, and was threatened by the powerful Persian Empire.

Alexander's empire

When Alexander became king of Macedon in 336 BC, Greece was dominated by Persia. In a series of brilliant military campaigns, Alexander defeated Persia and created his vast empire.



Macedonian Empire

Persia

The rich empire of Persia occupied much of modern Iraq, Turkey, and Iran. After Alexander had conquered the area, he tried to unite Macedonia and Persia by encouraging his generals to marry Persians. Alexander himself married Roxana, a princess from eastern Persia.

Stag comes from palace at Persepolis.



Persian silver stag ornament

Egypt

In 332 BC, Alexander conquered Egypt and was accepted as the new pharaoh. He founded the city of Alexandria, in northern Egypt, which became the most important city of the Greek-speaking world. When Alexander died in 323 BC, he was buried in a vast tomb in the centre of the city.

Alexander wears the pharaoh's crown



Battle of Issus

In 333 BC, the Macedonian army overwhelmed the more powerful Persian army led by Darius III (r. 336–330 BC) at the battle of Issus, Syria. The Persians were defeated again in 331 BC at Gaugamela near the River Tigris. After this battle, the Persian capital, Persepolis, was destroyed and the empire collapsed.

Relief of the Battle of Issus



Eastern empire

By 326 BC, Alexander had marched through Persia and had conquered Afghanistan and the Punjab. Although his troops were very loyal to him, they refused to go further than the River Indus.

Coin from Indus area



Death of Alexander

In 323 BC Alexander caught a fever in the city of Babylon. Although he was only 33, he died. This sudden death meant that Alexander did not have time to consolidate his rule or even name his successor. Within a few years of his death, the huge Macedonian Empire had collapsed.

Alexander's sarcophagus



Carved relief shows Alexander leading his troops.

Sarcophagus from the royal cemetery of Sidon, said to be the tomb of Alexander.

ALEXANDER THE GREAT

356 BC Born in Macedon

336 BC Succeeds his father to the Macedonian throne; quells rebellions in Greece

334 BC Leads his army into Persia and defeats a Persian army at the Granicus River

333 BC Defeats Darius III at Issus

331 BC Defeats Darius III again at Gaugamela, completing his conquest of the Persian Empire

326 BC Reaches the Indus, but is forced to turn back by his troops

323 BC Dies of fever in Babylon

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